Western interests will be tested in such a world. The relationship will only grow if it is firmly anchored on an approach of mutual benefit.

While this is clearly a relationship where the past is not a guide for the future, there are nevertheless some lessons from near history that are worth studying. For much of their relationship, the two nations have been exceptionally generous to each other. Where India is concerned, it saw Japan's 1905 victory over Russia as the beginning of an Asian resurgence. Thereafter, its anti-colonial contribution was directly impactful on India. Even now, the Indian public associates Japan inextricably with the saga of Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose. The subsequent era only built on this legacy further. India took an independent stance with regard to the Tokyo Tribunal and Justice Radhabinod Pal is a name that still resonates in many quarters. If the waiving of reparations and Japan's entry into the Asian Games were reflective of a unique Indian approach, it was repaid in full measure by the extension of yen loans and sustained economic support from the Japanese side. This is a relationship very much based on popular goodwill and the image of Japan in India has been consistently positive, especially in bridging modernity with tradition.

As for the image of India in Japan, it had multiple facets: as a source of Buddhism, for its intellectual traditions and its rich culture. But all of this existed under a glass ceiling of low growth rates and limited socio-economic transformation. So, when the first serious test came in the form of the 1998 nuclear tests, the relationship stumbled severely. The explanation for that lies largely in the duality of a Japan reconciling its Asian character with its Western interests.

At that time, Japan not only bought the Western narrative on non-proliferation but also the hyphenation of India-Pakistan and the accompanying analysis of Jammu and Kashmir. Consequently, Japan ended up as the prime mover of measures against India, including the UN Security Council Resolution 1172. It is important to reflect on this period because there are pointers for the future direction of ties. When India and Japan have dealt directly with each other rather than through Western mediation, their instincts have been positive. Japan must surely note how pragmatic Western countries and China eventually were in the aftermath of 1998.